

The Queen's Child

Savathûn looked down at her newest creation, smug satisfaction radiating from her face. Finally, she had made some real progress. As she gazed at the child, her grin faded briefly. This experiment... it reminded her of eons past, of her memories with her sisters on Fundament. The Krill, the proto-Hive—whatever you wanted to call them, once, they had been as innocent and free as this child in front of her. And, if this child survived... she would be free once again, too. She had contingencies if it failed, of course, but the child's continued survival and eventual mission could become the cornerstone of the next chapter of her life, should it succeed.

The child let out a brief cry, snapping Savathûn out from her thoughts. She double-checked the runes around the bed. *Good*, she thought. *The Imbaru is still flowing*. She was quite proud of this particular experiment. Using a combination of general Hive magic, the specifics of her Imbaru, and the knowledge from a few curious potions the Elikśni had made that seemed to be able to shift Darkness to Light—or at least, pull the Darkness out and allow Light to return—she'd been able to create a wormless Hive. This latest iteration of the experiment had survived longer than the worm that was supposed to inhabit it—early signs were indicating that the child could potentially outlive the Krill of old, provided nothing went wrong. One day, provided this child survived, she would have a mission for it—one that she could entrust to no one else. A mission that no Hive could take—not while they had a worm. Until that day, Savathûn would personally oversee the child's growth, ensuring its nutrition and education as her own personal agent. And, if the child continued to survive, the ramifications it could have for her...

Years later, that very same child stood in front of her, ready to learn his mission. While his Krill heritage was still obvious to her, he had taken on more and more traits of the Hive as he grew—he was somewhere in-between the two. Unless the child ran into one of Savathûn's siblings, no one else would know there was anything special about him at a glance.

"Aiash, child." Aiash was the name she had personally given him, once she had concluded he was going to survive—Aiash ur-Sathona. A name derived from that phrase most important, devoting him to who she once was, long ago...

"I await your words, Queen Mother."

“It is time for you to prove your worth. I have long trained you for a mission, but I have kept the details of my plans secret, even from you. Now, I require your aid. I want you to find out if an alliance with the Guardians of Earth can be forged,” Savathûn stated.

“I... do not understand. Why? And how?” Aiash looked baffled—a fitting reaction. She chuckled at that.

“We will get to the how in a moment. As for the why, I plan to betray the Witness.” Aiash’s eyes flared wide. No one defied the Witness and lived. “Yes, yes, I know. It’s a glorified suicide mission for me, but I want my freedom back. I cannot do it on my own; however, an army created by the enemy of the Witness, designed specifically to fight against its forces... With my mind and their paracausal power, I believe there might be a chance. The particulars of that plot are far off; there is much more to be done. But the first step lies in gaining access to their power. For that, I needed an emissary—one whose loyalty is to me, not the Witness or the Worm Gods. I needed you, child.”

“What I am asking of you is to go to Earth and see if an alliance could work. I’m not expecting you to jump straight to attempting to negotiate a ceasefire or anything. No, start small. Find a lone Guardian or two. Convince them you mean no harm; try to work with them. Report to me the details of your companions, your interactions, what you have witnessed them doing. They will likely be wary of you—entrust them with the truth, offer your aid—be cautious, and I have faith you will be able to find some others who will allow you to tag along.” *Of course, if you don’t succeed, at least your intelligence will be helpful, should I choose to pursue becoming a Lightbearer myself*, she thought.

Aiash looked up at the Witch Queen. “As you wish, Queen Mother. I am Aiash ur-Sathona, emissary of the Witch Queen, devoted of Sathona—the you who was without the Witness. I dedicate my life to this mission and to furthering the goal of returning your freedom. This pact is my life, my power, my weapon that I shall use to carve out a path for your will, however I must. *Aiat.*”

Savathûn smiled down at Aiash.

“*Aiat.*”